

CoARA ACTION PLAN (2025-2029)

FUNDACIÓ INSTITUT DE RECERCA EN ENERGIA DE
CATALUNYA



Shaping Energy for a Sustainable Future

CoARA ACTION PLAN

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1. Preamble

The Fundació Institut de Recerca en Energia de Catalunya (IREC) is a public research centre affiliated to the administration of the Generalitat de Catalunya, recognised as a CERCA centre and accredited as a TECNIO agent. Created in 2008, it is devoted to research and technological development in the field of energy and its production, transformation, transport, distribution and use. It focuses especially on technologies that allow the transition of the current energy model towards a new more sustainable energy model, mainly energy saving and efficiency technologies, production technologies and the clean use of energy and renewable energies. IREC's mission is to achieve scientific and technological excellence at the highest level in the field of energy, and promote the transfer of knowledge, technology, and results to society.

The IREC has been member of the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) since September 2024. Affiliating with CoARA implies the commitment to promote more qualitative, fair, diverse, transparent, and inclusive research assessment practices. The medium-term objective is to gradually promote the incorporation of new evaluation criteria and a new culture for the evaluation of IREC's research staff aligned with the spirit set out in CoARA's recommendations.

In line with this commitment, the IREC has drawn up a CoARA Action Plan for the period 2025-2029, in response to the Agreement on the Reform of Research Assessment signed at the time of joining the coalition.

The CoARA 2025-2029 Action Plan has been promoted by the Department of Corporate Development and Technology Transfer, following the recommendations of the document *Support for CoARA signatories in the preparation of action plans* and in line with the institute's Strategic Plan.

1.1. Research assessment at the IREC

The IREC approved its Open Science Policy in January 2025 with a section dedicated to evaluation. The Policy establishes the commitment to improve the ways in which researchers and research results are evaluated, prioritizing the quality of research and the behaviours and practices of open science.

The IREC is working on the development of a new Career Plan for all its staff, which will replace the current one, in force since 2019.

Research evaluation at the IREC is conducted in the following situations: contracting, evaluation, and promotion.

2. Action Plan 2025-2029

The 2025-2029 Action Plan is the first formulation of the IREC's internal proposal to improve research assessment, aimed at promoting higher quality and impactful research, aligned with CoARA's commitments. For this reason, its construction has been based on the 4 fundamental commitments:

1. Recognize the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of research.
2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators.
3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of Journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index.
4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment.

2.1. Action Plan proposal

The priority actions of IREC's 2025-2030 Action Plan consist in implementing the agreement's support commitments (from 5 to 10). These are summarized in the following table, which includes the lines of action, actions, managers, deadlines and the methodology for evaluating actions.

COARA COMMITMENT	ACTION LINES	ACTIONS	RESPONSIBLE	CALENDAR	INDICATOR
5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to	Guarantee IREC's institutional commitment to the CoARA principles	Creation of the CoARA Commission for research assessment	Direction	T4 2025	Creation of the Commission
		Annual follow-up of CoARA's Action Plan	CoARA Commission	2026 – 2029	Annual report on IREC's CoARA Action Plan
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes	Review and update IREC's Career Plan following the CoARA principles	Evaluation of the current Career Plan and adaptation of the criteria of the new Career Plan to the CoARA principles	CoARA Commission	T2 2026	Updated Career Plan
7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on	Develop an internal awareness strategy regarding CoARA principles	Preparation and publishing of informative materials, guides, etc. on the CoARA principles and research evaluation Organization of training activities on the CoARA principles.	CoARA Commission, Open Science WG	2026 - 2029	Elaborated material, recordings and other documentation at IREC's intranet

assessment criteria and processes as well as their use		Dissemination of CoARA actions within the IREC benefiting from the institute's communication channels			
8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition	Promote information exchange and best practices	Participation in Spain's CoARA National Chapter	CoARA Commission, Open Science WG	2025 - 2029	Annual report on the participation in the Spanish Chapter
10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research	Follow up successful cases and innovative assessment methods				

2.2. Governance and monitoring

The actions described within IREC's CoARA Action Plan 2025-2029 are part of those foreseen within the institute's Strategic Plan. This Plan has been developed by the Open Science team of the Corporate Development and Technology Transfer Department.

The CoARA Commission, once constituted, will meet periodically and at least once a year to evaluate the implementation and updating of the Action Plan.